

Dengue Fever

What is Dengue?

Dengue fever is a viral infection transmitted by the *Aedes aegypti* mosquito, primarily in tropical and subtropical regions including India.

There are 4 dengue virus serotypes. Infection with one type provides lifelong immunity to that type but not the others. Second infections can be more severe.

Symptoms

Classic dengue: sudden high fever (40 degrees C), severe headache, pain behind the eyes, muscle and joint pain (breakbone fever), skin rash, nausea and vomiting.

Symptoms appear 4-10 days after mosquito bite and last 2-7 days.

Warning signs of severe dengue: severe abdominal pain, persistent vomiting, bleeding gums, blood in vomit or stool, rapid breathing, fatigue, restlessness. Seek care immediately.

Medicines

There is NO specific antiviral medicine for dengue. Treatment is supportive.

Paracetamol (acetaminophen) for fever and pain. Do NOT use ibuprofen, aspirin, or naproxen as they increase bleeding risk.

Oral rehydration salts (ORS) for fluid replacement. IV fluids in hospital for severe cases.

Platelet transfusion only when platelet count drops below 10,000 or with active severe bleeding.

Emergency Actions

Go to hospital immediately if warning signs appear (see above).

Monitor platelet count daily during the critical phase (days 3-7 of illness).

Maintain fluid intake of at least 2-3 liters per day of water, coconut water, or ORS.

Do not give aspirin or ibuprofen under any circumstances.

Watch for signs of dengue shock: rapid weak pulse, cold clammy skin, confusion — call 112 immediately.

What You Should Do

Prevent mosquito bites: use DEET-based repellents, wear full-sleeve clothing, use bed nets.

Eliminate mosquito breeding: empty standing water from containers, flower pots, coolers weekly.

Rest adequately and maintain good nutrition during illness.

Follow up with doctor for repeat blood counts every 24-48 hours during illness.

The dengue vaccine (Dengvaxia) is available but only recommended for those previously infected.